KNOWLEDGE BASE

QUANTUM MECHANICS: AMPLITUDES, WAVES, AND SPIN

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The ideas behind the wave function, energy and momentum, and why the electron is a fermion

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1 RECOMMENDED READING AND SUPPORTIVE TEXTS

Recommended reading

The Feynman Lectures on Physics, Vol. III: Quantum Mechanics, Feynman, Leighton, and Sands
The source for most of what follows. Chapters 6 (spin one-half), 7 (amplitudes in time), 16 (amplitudes in position), and 17 (symmetry and conservation laws). The online edition is free and uses the same chapter, section, and equation numbers as the printed one. [Online edition]

Optional reading and supportive texts

2 WHY QUANTUM MECHANICS, AND WHAT THESE NOTES COVER

Quantum mechanics is the most accurate description we have of the electrons that hold molecules together. It is the reference that force fields are trained against (see the force fields notes), the theory behind every electronic-structure method (Hartree–Fock, DFT, coupled cluster), and the reason atoms have shells and chemistry has a periodic table.

These notes are not a survey of methods. They collect a small set of ideas that the rest of the subject is built on, developed from the smallest possible starting point and assuming only trigonometry (complex numbers are introduced when needed):

- **Amplitudes**: the state of a system is a list of complex numbers; probabilities are their squared sizes; phases matter only when amplitudes are combined.
- **Waves**: a state of definite energy and momentum is a plane wave $e^{i(kx-\omega t)}$, and $E = \hbar\omega$, $p = \hbar k$ say that energy and momentum are its rotation rates in time and in space.
- **Symmetry and conservation**: if the physics is unchanged by a shift or a rotation, the corresponding phase rate is conserved. This is Noether's theorem in quantum form.
- **Spin**: what rotation symmetry says about angular momentum, why the electron has two spin states, and why a rotation through 2π changes the sign of its state.
- **Fermions and bosons**: which of these facts are consequences of rotation symmetry and which need more (the spin-statistics theorem).

Most of this material was worked out in two interactive notebooks (`spinor_rotation.py` and `plane_waves_and_packets.py`, built with marimo) and is summarized here with the key equations. Units are those of the text unless stated; $\hbar = h/2\pi$ is Planck's constant divided by 2π.

3 AMPLITUDES, PROBABILITIES, AND PHASE

3.1 *An amplitude is an arrow*

A complex number $z = a + ib$ can be drawn as an arrow in a plane: a is the horizontal component (real part), b the vertical component (imaginary part). The arrow has a length $|z|$ and points at some angle from the horizontal axis. The arrows used here all have length 1 and are written

$$e^{i\theta} = \cos\theta + i\sin\theta,$$

the arrow of length 1 at angle θ (in radians). The angle θ is the *phase*.

The state of a quantum system is described by one or more such complex numbers, called *amplitudes*. The probability of an outcome is the squared length of its amplitude,

$$P = |a|^2.$$

Writing $a = |a|e^{i\varphi}$, the phase φ does not enter P. In particular, a and $-a$ give the same probability.

3.2 *Phases matter when amplitudes are combined*

If a particle can reach a detector by two routes, the amplitudes are added *before* squaring. For two routes of equal weight with amplitudes $a_1 = 1$ and $a_2 = e^{i\varphi}$,

$$P = \left|\frac{a_1 + a_2}{2}\right|^2 = \cos^2\!\left(\frac{\varphi}{2}\right).$$

The routes reinforce at $\varphi = 0$ ($P = 1$) and cancel at $\varphi = \pi$, that is for $a_2 = -1$ ($P = 0$), although $|a_2|^2 = 1$ in both cases. A sign that changes no probability on its own can therefore be detected by interference with an unchanged copy. This single observation underlies the strange behavior of spin in section 7.

3.3 *Overall phase is unobservable*

Multiplying *all* amplitudes of a state by the same phase changes no probability, and no interference between parts of that state. Only relative phases are physical. Consequently, adding a constant to every energy changes nothing observable (it multiplies every amplitude by the same turning arrow); only energy *differences* matter.

3.4 *An example: the hydrogen molecular ion*

Two protons share one electron. Write the state as (a_1, a_2), the amplitudes to find the electron near proton 1 or proton 2. Reflecting the system in the plane halfway between the protons turns (a_1, a_2) into (a_2, a_1). The state $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(1, 1)$ is unchanged; the state $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(1, -1)$ becomes $\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(-1, 1)$, which is minus itself. All probabilities are the same before and after, yet the second state has had its sign reversed. Two reflections restore any state, so a reflection can multiply a state only by $+1$ or -1. The same argument returns for the exchange of identical particles (section 9).

4 PLANE WAVES: ENERGY AND MOMENTUM AS ROTATION RATES

4.1 *Rotation in time:* ω

A particle of definite energy, observed at one fixed position, has the amplitude

$$e^{-i\omega t}.$$

The phase $-\omega t$ grows in proportion to time, so the arrow turns at a steady rate. ω **is the number of radians per unit time through which the arrow turns.** The period is $T = 2\pi/\omega$.

4.2 *Rotation in space:* k

A state of definite momentum has the amplitude e^{ikx} at position x. k **is the number of radians per unit distance through which the arrow turns** as one moves along the line, the spatial counterpart of ω. The wavelength is $\lambda = 2\pi/k$.

4.3 *A wave that moves*

Combining the two,

$$e^{i(kx-\omega t)},$$

in which the arrow at each position turns in time at rate ω while neighboring positions are turned relative to one another at rate k. A point of fixed phase satisfies $kx - \omega t = \text{const}$, so the pattern moves at the *phase velocity*

$$v_{\text{phase}} = \frac{\omega}{k}.$$

This is the speed of the crests, not yet the speed of the particle (section 5).

4.4 *Why the amplitude must be complex*

The amplitude $e^{i(kx-\omega t)}$ has length 1 everywhere and at all times, so the probability of finding the particle is uniform and constant. This is the correct description of a state of definite energy and momentum: the momentum is exactly known, so the position is completely undetermined. A real wave such as $\cos(kx - \omega t)$ would not do, because its square has nodes (positions of zero probability) and oscillates in time.

4.5 *Energy and momentum*

The physical content is in two relations,

$$E = \hbar\omega, \qquad p = \hbar k.$$

Energy is the rotation rate in time; momentum is the rotation rate in space. The wavelength is therefore $\lambda = 2\pi/k = h/p$ (the de Broglie relation).

WHERE THEY COME FROM. Both have the same origin as the conservation laws. Suppose the physical situation is unchanged by a shift in position, as in empty space. A plane wave e^{ikx} is then a state that a shift only multiplies by a phase, proportional to the size of the shift, whose rate is k. A phase factor of this kind cannot change as time passes, so the rate k is conserved: this is the quantum form of conservation of momentum. The same argument for shifts in time gives conservation of energy, with rate ω. The constant $\hbar$ converts these rates to the momentum and energy of classical mechanics, to which they must agree for large systems; its value is fixed by experiment.

WHY ONE CONSTANT SERVES BOTH. Relativity requires it: energy and momentum are the time part and space part of one four-vector, and so are frequency and wave number. A particle at rest has the pure time rotation $e^{-iE_0 t/\hbar}$. An observer who sees it moving with speed v uses the Lorentz-transformed time $t = \gamma(t' - vx'/c^2)$ and finds $E_0 t = E't' - p'x'$ with $E' = \gamma E_0$ and $p' = E'v/c^2$, so the amplitude is $e^{-i(E't'-p'x')/\hbar}$, with $\omega = E'/\hbar$ and $k = p'/\hbar$.

FREE PARTICLE DISPERSION. For a slow particle of mass m, $E = p^2/2m$, so

$$\omega(k) = \frac{\hbar k^2}{2m}.$$

5 WAVE PACKETS: WHEN A LUMP MOVES LIKE A PARTICLE

A single plane wave has the same probability everywhere, so it cannot describe a particle that is *somewhere*. A localized particle is a superposition of plane waves with wave numbers close to k_0:

$$\psi(x,t) = \sum_k a(k)\, e^{i(kx-\omega(k)t)}.$$

Where the waves are in step their amplitudes add; elsewhere they cancel, leaving a lump. The weights $a(k)$ are *amplitudes* with a common phase (a coherent superposition), not Boltzmann-type probabilities (which would give an incoherent mixture and no lump).

5.1 *Uncertainty*

Take $a(k)$ to be a bell curve centered on k_0 with root-mean-square width σ_k, all components in phase at $x = 0$ when $t = 0$. Then $|\psi(x,0)|^2$ is also a bell curve, with width σ_x, and

$$\sigma_x \sigma_k = \tfrac{1}{2}, \qquad \text{that is} \qquad \Delta x\, \Delta p = \frac{\hbar}{2},$$

with $\Delta x = \sigma_x$ and $\Delta p = \hbar\sigma_k$. This is the uncertainty principle: a property of the state, not a measurement error. The bell curve (Gaussian) is the shape that makes the product as small as possible. A narrow lump in position requires a broad range of k, and the reverse.

5.2 *The lump moves at the classical velocity*

Expand the rotation rate about k_0:

$$\omega(k) = \omega_0 + v\,(k-k_0) + \frac{\hbar}{2m}(k-k_0)^2, \qquad v = \left.\frac{d\omega}{dk}\right|_{k_0} = \frac{\hbar k_0}{m} = \frac{p_0}{m}.$$

The linear term turns x into $x - vt$ in the sum, so alone it would slide the pattern along unchanged at $v = p_0/m$, the velocity of a classical particle. This lump speed is the *group velocity* $d\omega/dk$, which differs from the crest speed ω/k.

5.3 *The lump spreads*

The quadratic term makes the components fall out of step, and the lump widens. For the Gaussian packet the probability stays a bell curve centered at $x = vt$ with width

$$\sigma(t) = \sigma_x \sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{t}{t_s}\right)^2}, \qquad t_s = \frac{2m\sigma_x^2}{\hbar}.$$

5.4 *When is a particle classical?*

A particle behaves classically if it travels far, compared with its own size, before spreading matters. The distance traveled in time t_s is $vt_s = 2k_0\sigma_x^2$, so

$$\frac{vt_s}{\sigma_x} = 2k_0\sigma_x, \qquad k_0\sigma_x = \frac{p_0\sigma_x}{\hbar} = \frac{p_0}{2\Delta p}.$$

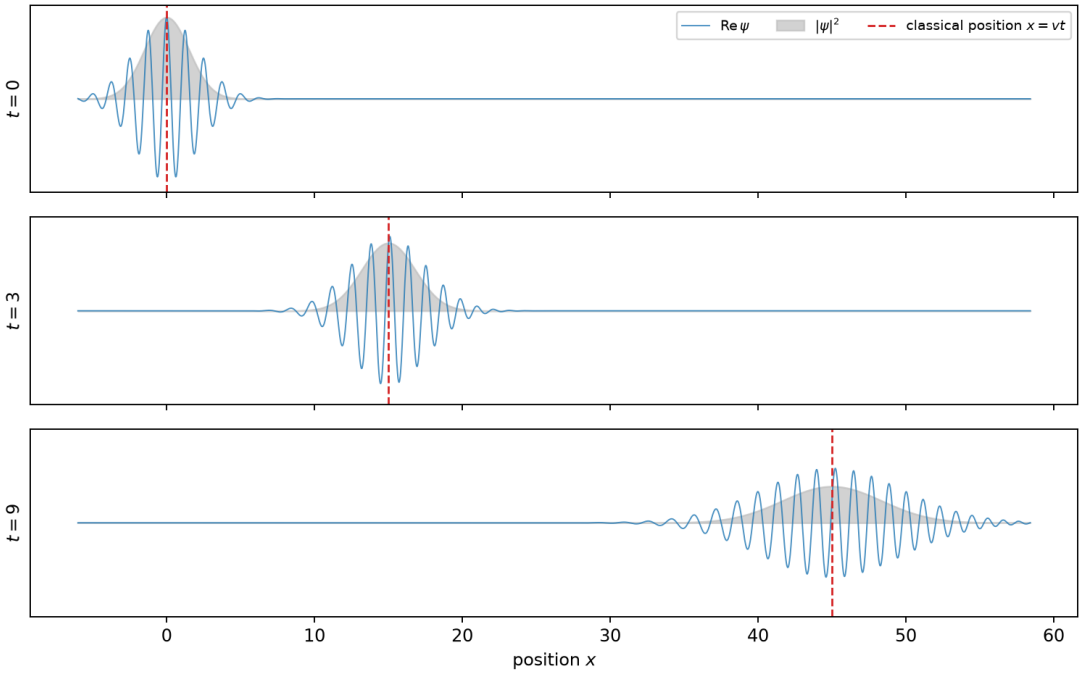


Figure 1: A Gaussian packet with $k_0 = 5$ *and* $\sigma_x = 1.5$ *(units with* $\hbar = m = 1$*) at three times. Grey: probability; blue: real part of the amplitude (the individual waves inside the lump); dashed: classical position* $x = vt$.

The single number $k_0\sigma_x$ is large exactly when the momentum is known to a small fraction of itself. When $k_0\sigma_x \gg 1$ the lump contains many wavelengths and travels many widths before spreading, so it follows $x = vt$. When $k_0\sigma_x \sim 1$ no path can be spoken of.

Particle	Localized to	$k_0\sigma_x$	Spreading time t_s
Electron, kinetic energy 1 eV	1 nm	about 5	about 17 fs
Dust grain, 1 mg at 1 mm/s	1 μm	about 10^{19}	about 6×10^8 years

NUMERICAL NOTE. A sum over N evenly spaced values of k repeats with period $2\pi/\Delta k$, so a finite sum shows copies of the lump. With Gaussian weights, about 10 components give a clean lump at $t = 0$, and roughly $5\sqrt{1 + (t/t_s)^2}$ are needed as it spreads; equal weights leave a sidelobe of about 5% for any N. The lump width is set by the bandwidth, never by N.

6 ROTATIONS AND ANGULAR MOMENTUM

6.1 *Why study rotations*

Symmetries are tied to conserved quantities (Noether's theorem). If the physics is unchanged when everything is rotated about some axis, the component of angular momentum along that axis does not change in time. The way a quantum state transforms under rotation therefore determines what spin is.

6.2 *Rotation matrices*

In the plane, the matrix that rotates every vector through θ is

$$R(\theta) = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta & -\sin\theta \\ \sin\theta & \cos\theta \end{pmatrix}.$$

Two rotations in succession multiply their matrices; in the plane the order is immaterial (a then b is $a + b$). In three dimensions there is a basic rotation about each axis, for example

$$R_z(\theta) = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta & -\sin\theta & 0 \\ \sin\theta & \cos\theta & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

with R_x and R_y similar. **In three dimensions the order of rotations matters.** Rotating about x then y gives a different orientation than y then x (unless one of the angles is $0°$ or $180°$). This non-commutation is the only property of 3D rotations needed below. For small rotations the mismatch is exact: rotating by ϵ about x, then y, then back about x and back about y gives approximately a rotation by ϵ^2 about z,

$$R_x(\epsilon)R_y(\epsilon)R_x(-\epsilon)R_y(-\epsilon) \approx R_z(\epsilon^2),$$

the group-level form of $[J_x, J_y] = iJ_z$.

6.3 *The J matrices*

For a very small angle, $R(\epsilon) \approx 1 + \epsilon K$, where $K = dR/d\theta|_{\theta=0}$ is the derivative of the rotation matrix at zero angle. A rotation through a finite angle is many small ones,

$$R(\theta) = \lim_{n\to\infty} \left(1 + \frac{\theta}{n}K\right)^n = e^{\theta K},$$

the matrix analogue of continuously compounded interest. Defining $J = iK$ gives

$$R(\theta) = e^{-i\theta J}.$$

The factor i makes J have real eigenvalues, as required of a quantity whose measured values are real. So **each entry of J is i times the derivative, at zero angle, of the corresponding entry of the rotation matrix.** For ordinary 3D vectors, $J_z = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -i & 0 \\ i & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ has eigenvalues $-1, 0, +1$, and the same holds for J_x and J_y, since no direction in space is special.

6.4 *Spin number and the phase* $e^{-im\theta}$

The eigenvalues of J_z are the possible values m of the spin component along z. For ordinary vectors $m = +1, 0, -1$, and the system is said to have **spin 1** (the spin number j is the largest m). Since $R = e^{-i\theta J}$, **a rotation through θ about z multiplies the amplitude of the level with value m by $e^{-im\theta}$.** For integer m all these phases equal 1 at $\theta = 2\pi$: an ordinary vector returns to itself after a full turn.

6.5 *Conservation of* m

Take a state of definite m in a situation unchanged by rotations about z. Turning the state then letting it evolve gives the same result as evolving then turning. Turning the initial state multiplies it by $e^{-im\theta}$, so the evolved state, when turned, is multiplied by the same factor: evolution leaves m unchanged, whatever the details of the interaction. The same argument for shifts of position and time gives momentum and energy (section 4). In matrix language the statement is $[H, J] = 0$, so $d\langle J\rangle/dt = i\langle[H, J]\rangle = 0$.

A test: a spinning object in a magnetic field along $\hat{n}$ precesses about $\hat{n}$; the situation is unchanged by rotations about $\hat{n}$, so only the component of angular momentum *along the field* is conserved while the others oscillate.

7 SPIN ONE-HALF

7.1 *The electron is not spin 1*

In a Stern–Gerlach experiment a beam of silver atoms (magnetic moment of a single unpaired electron) passes through a non-uniform magnetic field, which deflects each atom according to its spin component along the field. A spin-1 system would give three beams. Experimentally **exactly two beams emerge**, for any orientation of the magnet. The electron's state has two amplitudes.

Three separate statements are involved, and only the first can be addressed with rotations:

1. **Which spins can exist.** Rotation symmetry, together with the unobservability of the overall sign of a state, allows $j = 0, \frac{1}{2}, 1, \frac{3}{2}, \ldots$ Half-integer spin is *permitted*; experiment shows that nature uses it.

2. **Half-integer spin implies a fermion.** This is the spin-statistics theorem (section 9); it does not follow from rotation symmetry alone.

3. **Consequences.** The exclusion principle produces atomic shells and chemistry.

7.2 *A model with two amplitudes*

The smallest model has two amplitudes of unit size, with relative phase ϕ and common phase θ:

$$a_1 = e^{i(\theta-\phi/2)}, \qquad a_2 = e^{i(\theta+\phi/2)}.$$

Combining the two as in section 3, $P = \cos^2(\phi/2)$, independent of θ. Two descriptions (θ, ϕ) give the same pair (a_1, a_2) also when related by $(\theta, \phi) \to (\theta + \pi, \phi + 2\pi)$: advancing ϕ by 2π flips the sign of the pair, as does advancing θ by π.

THE VALUE OF m. The observable quantity is the relative phase ϕ: the direction of the arrow $a_1^* a_2 = e^{i\phi}$ (for the electron, the direction of the spin in the xy-plane). A rotation of space through α must advance it by exactly α. If the rotation multiplies the two amplitudes by $e^{\mp i m \alpha}$, then ϕ advances by $2m\alpha$, so $2m = 1$ and

$$m = \pm\tfrac{1}{2}.$$

The amplitudes are the square root of the observable arrow. In a two-dimensional world the same argument allows any real m (such particles are called anyons); restricting m to integers and half-integers needs the non-commutation of 3D rotations.

7.3 *The matrices*

With $m = \pm\frac{1}{2}$, a rotation through θ about z multiplies the two amplitudes by $e^{\mp i\theta/2}$:

$$U_z(\theta) = \begin{pmatrix} e^{-i\theta/2} & 0 \\ 0 & e^{i\theta/2} \end{pmatrix}.$$

The rotations about x and y are the 2×2 matrices that multiply in the same way as the ordinary rotations:

$$U_x(\theta)=\begin{pmatrix}\cos\frac{\theta}{2} & -i\sin\frac{\theta}{2}\\ -i\sin\frac{\theta}{2} & \cos\frac{\theta}{2}\end{pmatrix},\qquad U_y(\theta)=\begin{pmatrix}\cos\frac{\theta}{2} & -\sin\frac{\theta}{2}\\ \sin\frac{\theta}{2} & \cos\frac{\theta}{2}\end{pmatrix}.$$

Obtaining $J=iK$ exactly as before gives J_x, J_y, J_z equal to the **Pauli matrices divided by 2**. These matrices turn the state through θ; some texts turn the coordinate axes instead, which replaces each matrix by its inverse and writes $e^{+i\theta J}$. The physics is identical.

7.4 *A 2π rotation changes the sign*

With $m=\pm\frac{1}{2}$ a rotation through 2π multiplies both amplitudes by $e^{\mp i\pi}=-1$ (for integer m, by 1). By section 3 this alters no probability of the rotated state on its own; it is detected by splitting a beam, rotating one part through θ, and recombining. For spin 1 the detection probability repeats every 2π; for spin $\frac{1}{2}$ it repeats only every 4π.

7.5 *Two matrices for every rotation*

Because a state and its negative are indistinguishable by themselves, a rotation cannot tell U from $-U$: **every rotation has two valid 2×2 matrices.** Writing $(a,b)=(\cos\frac{\varphi}{2},\sin\frac{\varphi}{2})$, the matrix $U_z=\mathrm{diag}(a-ib,\ a+ib)$ traces a circle with one full circuit per 4π, while the ordinary 3×3 rotation it implements repeats every 2π. At $\varphi=2\pi$, R is the identity while $U=-1$. The map from 2×2 matrices to 3×3 rotations is two-to-one: these are the groups SU(2) and SO(3), and SU(2) is the *double cover* of SO(3). The correspondence is

$$R_{ij}=\tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Tr}\big(\sigma_i\,U\,\sigma_j\,U^\dagger\big),$$

where $\sigma_i=2J_i$ are the Pauli matrices; it is identical for U and $-U$.

8 THE BELT TRICK: A PICTURE OF THE 4π ROTATION

The sign change can be seen as a shape. A belt joins a fixed wall to a plate that is turned about the vertical axis. At each point along the belt the cross-section has an *orientation*; at the wall it is the identity and at the plate it is the rotation through the angle φ by which the plate has been turned. The belt is a continuous path of orientations from the identity to the plate's orientation. (The explicit family of belts used for the figures is given by unit quaternions, which are the 2×2 matrices above: $U=w-i(x\sigma_x+y\sigma_y+z\sigma_z)$.)

- At $\varphi=2\pi$ the plate is back in its starting orientation but the belt is not: it has one full twist. The orientation of the plate says only that it faces as it did; the belt also records that a full turn has been made.
- Turning further does not add a second twist. The belt untwists, and at 4π plate and belt are both as they started.
- No smooth way of turning the plate leaves the belt flat at both $\varphi=0$ and $\varphi=2\pi$, but for 4π there is one.

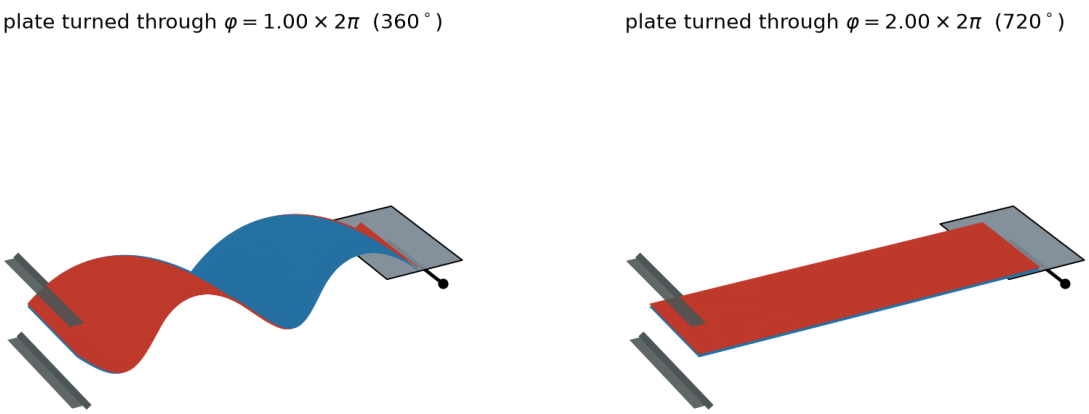


Figure 2: The belt after the plate has turned through 2π (left: the plate faces as it started, but the belt carries one full twist) and through 4π (right: the twist has gone and the belt is flat again). The red and blue sides are the two faces of the belt.

THE SAME FACT AS THE SPINOR SIGN. Following the belt from the wall, where $U = 1$, fixes a continuous choice of sign for U. At the plate this is the electron's matrix $U_z(\varphi)$: -1 at 2π, $+1$ at 4π. A belt with one twist is the picture of the sign -1; an untwisted belt is $+1$.

CAVEAT. The model is a family of frames (the centre line follows the cross-section's axis), so the plate is carried round a loop as the belt curls. It is not a self-avoiding belt with both ends pinned in position.

8.1 *The space of rotations as a ball*

Every orientation is a rotation through some angle in $[0, \pi]$ about some axis, so it can be drawn as a point in a ball of radius π: direction from the centre is the axis, distance is the angle, the centre is the identity. Rotations through π about opposite axes are the same, so **opposite points on the surface are identified**: a path leaving the ball at one point continues from the opposite one.

Turning the plate about the vertical moves its orientation straight up from the centre, out of the surface at $\varphi = \pi$, back in from the opposite point, and to the centre at 2π: a closed path crossing the surface once. Turning through 4π crosses the surface twice. A deformation of a closed path can create or remove crossings only in *pairs* (two can merge and cancel), so a lone crossing can never disappear. Hence the 2π path can never be shrunk to the centre and the 4π path can.

In terms of the matrices: the 4π path lifts to a closed path of U (it ends at $U = +1$) and can be shrunk; the 2π path lifts to a path from $U = +1$ to $U = -1$, which is not closed.

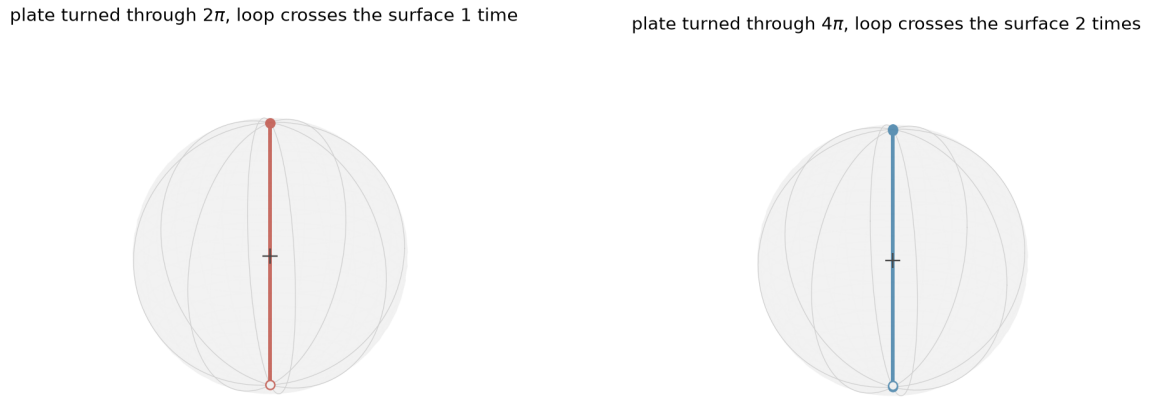


Figure 3: The plate's orientation as a path in the ball of rotations. Left: 2π, one surface crossing, cannot be shrunk. Right: 4π (shown partly shrunk), two crossings that approach and cancel, after which the path contracts to a point.

9 BOSONS, FERMIONS, AND WHAT ROTATIONS DO NOT TELL US

All known particles fall into two classes, distinguished by two related properties:

- **Rotation.** The state of a boson is unchanged by a 2π rotation; the state of a fermion changes sign, and 4π restores it. Bosons have integer spin, fermions half-integer spin.
- **Exchange.** Interchanging two identical bosons leaves the joint state unchanged (symmetric); interchanging two identical fermions changes its sign (antisymmetric).

Bosons (photons, for example) can occupy the same quantum state in any number. Fermions (electrons, protons, neutrons) cannot: this is the **Pauli exclusion principle**, which gives atoms their shell structure and underlies chemistry.

WHAT ROTATION SYMMETRY GIVES. That half-integer spin is allowed, and that it brings a sign change at 2π.

WHAT IT DOES NOT GIVE. That half-integer spin means fermion. This link between rotation and exchange is the *spin-statistics theorem* (Pauli, 1940), proved in relativistic quantum field theory from Lorentz invariance, locality, and positive energy. A heuristic: exchanging two particles resembles a half-turn of the pair, which would contribute the sign $(-1)^{2j}$ found above for a 2π rotation. Rigorous proofs are considerably more demanding. Exchange itself follows the pattern of the reflection example in section 3: applying it twice restores the state, so exchange multiplies the joint state by $+1$ or -1.

10 TECHNICAL NOTES

These are the more advanced versions of arguments made above. They need linear algebra and some group theory.

10.1 *Quantization of m from commutators*

Non-commutation gives $J_z = -i[J_x, J_y]$ and, with $J_\pm = J_x \pm iJ_y$,

$$[J_z, J_\pm] = \pm J_\pm.$$

If $J_z|m\rangle = m|m\rangle$, then $J_+|m\rangle$ has J_z-eigenvalue exactly $m+1$ and $J_-|m\rangle$ has $m-1$: the values of m come in steps of 1. In a finite number of states the ladder must stop at a top state ($J_+|m_{max}\rangle = 0$) and a bottom state ($J_-|m_{min}\rangle = 0$). Since $\|J_\pm|m\rangle\|^2 = j(j+1) - m(m \pm 1)$, vanishing at the ends forces $m_{min} = -m_{max} \equiv -j$, and N steps of 1 from $-j$ to $+j$ give $2j = N - 1$, an integer. The commutator loop above is the same for every spin (the error against $R_z(\epsilon^2)$ shrinks like ϵ^3), so the non-commuting structure is representation-independent and j labels which representation one has.

10.2 *Neighboring levels differ by one*

A heuristic version without commutators: the spin direction is set by products of amplitudes of neighboring levels, with relative phase $e^{i(m_1 - m_2)\theta}$ under a rotation by θ. This phase must equal the geometric angle θ of the spin direction, so the spacing is exactly 1. Rotating 180° about y interchanges up and down, so the set of m is symmetric about zero. For N levels, $j = (N-1)/2$, and the effect of a 2π rotation is

N levels	j	m values	2π rotation
1	0	0	unchanged
2	$\frac{1}{2}$	$\pm\frac{1}{2}$	sign change
3	1	$-1, 0, +1$	unchanged
4	$\frac{3}{2}$	$\pm\frac{1}{2}, \pm\frac{3}{2}$	sign change

An even number of levels always produces a sign change. The first guess for two levels, $m = \pm 1$, fails: at $\phi = \pi$ both amplitudes get -1 (an unobservable common sign), so $+x$ never becomes $-x$.

10.3 *Noether's theorem in quantum mechanics*

The generator in $U(\hat{n}, \theta) = e^{-i\theta\hat{n}\cdot\mathbf{J}}$ is $\mathbf{J}$ itself. If H is rotationally invariant, $UHU^\dagger = H$ for every rotation, and expanding to first order in θ gives $[H, \hat{n}\cdot\mathbf{J}] = 0$. The Heisenberg equation then gives

$$\frac{d\langle\mathbf{J}\rangle}{dt} = i\langle[H, \mathbf{J}]\rangle = 0.$$

The conserved quantity is literally the generator of the symmetry. A magnetic field breaks rotation symmetry but $H = \omega\,\hat{n}\cdot\mathbf{J}$ is still invariant under rotations about $\hat{n}$, so only $\hat{n}\cdot\mathbf{J}$ is conserved and the other components precess.

10.4 *Projective representations and the double cover*

Quantum states are rays, so symmetry only requires $U(\text{rot}_2)U(\text{rot}_1) = \pm U(\text{rot}_2 \circ \text{rot}_1)$. SO(3) is not simply connected ($\pi_1 = \mathbb{Z}_2$): a 2π rotation is a loop that cannot be shrunk to a point, but a 4π loop can. Its projective representations are therefore exactly the ordinary representations of its simply connected double cover, SU(2), which is where half-integer spins come from; the belt trick shows the loop. The relativistic analogue is the double cover $SL(2, \mathbb{C})$ of the Lorentz group, which is where Weyl and Dirac spinors live.

10.5 *Why the groups matter in practice*

Equivariant machine-learned force fields (see the force fields notes) are built on exactly this representation theory: features are labeled by j (angular momentum order), and rotating the input molecule acts on them by the matrices above. A rotation of the molecule must rotate energies trivially and forces as vectors; the spin-1 representation is the force.